Dharma War: Narrative Design Execution Plan

A step-by-step plan to pin down world, story, and characters to workload-estimation quality

---

What This Plan Is For

The goal of this process is not to write the game. It is to produce a **Scope-Locked Narrative Document** — the narrative equivalent of your mechanic lock from Phase 0 of your existing TODO list [1]. When this plan is complete, you will be able to answer every production planning question about story, world, and characters without committing to specific dialogue or individual scenes. That is the threshold for budgeting and workforce decisions.

The Narrative Design Guide is explicit about where to stop: "For your scope-locked GDD, you need Steps 1, 2, and 3 completed and locked. Steps 4 and 5 happen during production. Do not let yourself begin Step 4 until Steps 1–3 are locked." [2] This plan operationalises exactly that stopping point for your specific game.

Before You Start: The One Rule to Internalize

Your game's core verbs are **Plan, Position, Strike, Judge, Nurture** [3]. Every narrative decision you make during this process must be tested against those five verbs. If a story beat, character, faction, or world element cannot connect to at least one of them, it does not exist in this version of the game [2]. This is your single most important scope-control mechanism during narrative design.

Phase N1 — The Story Seed

Time estimate: 1 focused session (2–3 hours)
Output: 1 sentence

This is the conceptual anchor for every decision that follows. Until this sentence exists and is locked, nothing else in this plan can be done reliably.

The Story Seed is a one-sentence logline structured as: **protagonist** + **goal** + **obstacle** + **stakes** [2]. It is not a tagline or a marketing line. It is the internal compass. The Narrative Design Guide provides a working example calibrated to your game: *"A kingdom's conscience — its unseen strategist — must guide a fractured army through a war where every victory requires a dharmic betrayal, knowing that the kind of victory they win will determine the kind of peace they inherit."* [2]

What to do:

- Write 3–5 candidate loglines. They will all be wrong at first.
- For each candidate, ask: does it name the protagonist's role, their goal, the obstacle that makes the goal hard, and what is ultimately at stake beyond the battle?
- Lock the one that best captures the emotional promise of the game — not what happens, but what it will feel like to play it.
- Write it at the top of a new document titled **Narrative Spine**. Every subsequent output in this plan lives in that document or references it.

Pass condition:

You can read the sentence to someone with no knowledge of the game and they understand the emotional territory — not the plot, the emotional territory.

Phase N2 — The World Spine

Time estimate: 2–3 sessions (4–6 hours total)
Output: 1–2 pages in the Narrative Spine document

Worldbuilding at this stage is not lore-writing. It is conflict-architecture. The Narrative Design Guide is clear: "Underlying conflicts probably define the world more than anything else." [2] You are not building a geography or a history — you are building the engine of your story.

Step N2.1 — Define the Three World Sentences

Write exactly one sentence for each of the following. These sentences define the *process*, not the state [2]:

- **The Defining Process:** Not "the kingdom is at war" but *what is changing right now, at the civilisational level, that the war is accelerating or preventing?* Example: "The dharmic order that gave this kingdom its shared identity is fracturing as different factions answer the question 'what does duty require?' with incompatible answers."
- **The Primary Tension:** Two forces that cannot coexist in their current form. For Dharma War, this is not Good vs. Evil — it is competing interpretations of dharma. The war is the stage on which this incompatibility becomes violent [2].
- **The Human Face:** Name one specific person on each side of the primary tension whose personal conflict *is* the civilisational conflict made visible. These may or may not be your protagonist.

Step N2.2 — Build the Conflict Triangle

Draw a triangle. Label the three points: **Civilisational conflict** (top), **Factional conflict** (left), **Personal conflict** (right) [2]. For your world, populate each point with 2–3 concrete specifics. This triangle is your scene-writing test: every major story scene should have at least two of the three active simultaneously. If only one is active, the scene is too thin [2].

Step N2.3 — Design the Factions (Mass Effect Method)

For each faction in the war (aim for 2–4 distinct factions, not just two sides), fill in the following three statements [2]:

1. "This faction is **right** that..."
2. "This faction is **blind** to the fact that..."

3. "Inside this faction, there are those who believe [shared ideology] but argue bitterly about [method/cost/compromise]..."

This structure prevents faction monoliths — the single biggest worldbuilding failure in games of this type [2]. For your game specifically: every faction needs a defensible answer to "what does dharma require of us here?" The war is between competing dharmic interpretations, which is both historically accurate to Indian epic tradition and dramatically richer than a simple good-vs-evil axis [2].

Step N2.4 — Write the Four World Properties Check

Before finalising the World Spine, verify your world satisfies all four properties from the Narrative Design Guide [2]:

Property	Test Question	Your Answer
Believable	Does the world follow its own rules consistently?	
Open	Are there gaps the player can project meaning into, or is everything over-explained?	
Tangible	Has every thematic idea (dharma, sacrifice, loyalty) been made into a specific person or place?	
Dynamic	Is the world defined by a *process* (something changing), not a static state?	

Pass condition:

Someone reading the World Spine can understand what the war is *actually about* beyond territory, who the sides are and why they're both right and wrong, and can name the human face of the conflict.

Phase N3 — The Three-Act Story Treatment

Time estimate: 3–5 sessions (8–12 hours total)
Output: 2–3 pages added to the Narrative Spine document

This is the scope-lock document for narrative. The Narrative Design Guide calls it the equivalent of the mechanic lock in Phase 0: "If a new story idea does not fit in this treatment, it does not exist in this game." [2] Write it in prose, no dialogue, no scene descriptions — just what happens, to whom, what it costs them, and what changes.

Act 1 (25% of campaign chapters): Setup

Write a paragraph covering [2]:

- The world as it is before the protagonist's involvement escalates
- The protagonist's role and their position relative to the war
- The **Inciting Incident** — the specific event that makes the war unavoidable for them personally (not geopolitically, but *personally*)
- The introduction of the central emotional stakes — a named civilian, a relationship, a loyalty — that will be tested throughout

Applied to your chapter structure: Act 1 should encompass roughly the first 20–25% of chapters, introduce the human cost, and deliver the first death or loss that establishes that this game is serious about its emotional promises [2].

Act 2 (50% of campaign chapters): Confrontation

Write two paragraphs [2]:

First paragraph — Rising Action to Midpoint: How the protagonist pursues their goal against escalating obstacles. What dharmic dilemmas appear? What relationships deepen? What costs are paid?

Then write the **Midpoint Reversal** sentence — the single event that *recontextualises what the war is actually about*. This is not just a plot twist; it is a revelation that changes the meaning of everything that preceded it [2].

Second paragraph — Midpoint to All Is Lost: How does the Midpoint Reversal change the protagonist's situation? What do they sacrifice? Where do the Consequential Forks occur — the route choices where the unchosen path continues to exist as a scar on the story [2]? End with the **"All Is Lost" moment** — the point where the player's accumulated choices have placed them in an impossible position.

Act 3 (25% of campaign chapters): Resolution / The Reckoning

Write one paragraph covering [2]:

- The Reckoning Chapter — the final confrontation where every choice the player has made is tested simultaneously
- Whether the resolution is a victory, a tragedy, or an ambiguous inheritance
- The Legacy Epilogue shape — not the content, but the *type* of world that results from the campaign's choices

The Three Structural Sentences

Immediately after the treatment, write these three sentences in isolation [2]. These are your narrative skeleton:

1. **Inciting Incident:** "The event that makes the war unavoidable is..."
2. **Midpoint Reversal:** "The thing that changes what the war is ABOUT is..."
3. **All Is Lost:** "The point where the player's choices have placed them in an impossible position is..."

Pass condition:

Reading the treatment aloud takes 5–7 minutes. A listener can tell you: what the war is about, who the protagonist is and what drives them, what major sacrifice the player will be asked to make, and roughly how it ends. They cannot tell you dialogue or individual scenes — that is correct.

Phase N4 — The Cast Design Sheet

Time estimate: 3–4 sessions (6–10 hours total)
Output: 1 structured page per named character, added as an appendix to Narrative Spine

Characters are built *after* the world and story because they must serve the story's conflict, not the other way around. The Narrative Design Guide is clear on sequence: "For each major character, define what the player does with them in battle before defining who they are in dialogue." [2]

Step N4.1 — Define the Cast Roster

Before writing any individual character, define the roster structure:

- How many **major playable characters** (those with full support chains and dharmic path splits)?
- How many **secondary playable characters** (those with abbreviated arcs)?
- How many **named civilians** (3–4 recurring non-combatants whose survival is under player influence)?
- How many **named antagonists** (ideological opponents, not just tactical obstacles)?
- How many **allied commanders** (NPCs with personality systems)?

The total cast determines your writing workload for production. This roster *is* a production scope decision [1].

Step N4.2 — Assign Arc Types Before Writing Anything

For every named character, assign one of three arc types before writing a single word of their personality or backstory [2]:

Arc Type	What It Means	How Many in Cast
Positive Arc	Character transforms for the better; internal Need is met	Minority — too many produces optimism fatigue
Negative Arc	War breaks them, or they achieve Want at the cost of Need — a tragedy, not a villain arc	The most morally powerful arc type for war stories
Flat Arc	Character does not change, but their constancy changes the world — the moral anchor	1–2 maximum; these are foils for everyone who does change

A cast without all three types is a thematically incomplete war story [2].

Step N4.3 — Write the GMC Card for Each Major Character

For each major playable character, fill in all six cells of the GMC framework [2]. These must be in tension — the external and internal lines must pull in different directions, or there is no arc:

GMC Dimension	Question
External Goal	What specific, tangible thing are they trying to achieve? (Not "survive" — something specific)
External Motivation	Why are they pursuing this? What backstory makes the goal feel inevitable?
External Conflict	What obstacle stands between them and their goal? (Tactical + dharmic)
Internal Goal	What do they need emotionally to feel whole? (Usually subconscious)
Internal Motivation	What wound or formative experience creates this need?
Internal Conflict	What belief do they hold that is wrong or incomplete — the thing the arc will break?

Step N4.4 — Write the Want vs. Need Sentence Pair

For every character with a Dharmic Path Split (branching promotion), write [2]:

- "What [Name] **wants** is..." — the pragmatic power path, short-term relief
- "What [Name] **needs** is..." — the dharmic restraint path, long-term wholeness

These must be genuinely different. The promotion choice forces the player to either serve the Want or the Need — and both must be defensible [2].

Step N4.5 — Write the Flaw + Handicap

For every major character [2]:

- **Flaw:** Something they do wrong by choice — a moral failing. This makes them responsible for their suffering and creates conflict.

- **Handicap:** Something that limits them that is not their fault. This creates sympathy. A character who *has trauma* is a biography bullet point. A character who *is harsh with recruits because of what happened to their unit in the last war* is a person.

Step N4.6 — Write the First Impression + Hidden Depth

For every character, define [2]:

- **First impression:** What would a player assume about this character from their class, role, and opening lines?
- **Hidden depth:** What does sustained interaction reveal that contradicts or complicates the first impression?

The depth must be earned through interaction, never front-loaded. A character who explains their backstory in the opening scene has no depth left to discover [2].

Step N4.7 — Write the Battlefield Role Before the Personality

For every playable character, answer this first: *what does the player do with them in battle?* [2] Their personality, dialogue texture, and emotional register should *resonate with* — not contradict — that tactical identity. A rescue-focused unit whose dialogue is about abandoning people is a contradiction. A unit who always positions on the front line should have something in their personality that makes that choice feel character-expressive.

Step N4.8 — The Iceberg Page (Internal Reference Only)

For every named playable character, write one private page answering [2]:

- Where were they born and what was their life before the war?
- Who did they love and what did they lose before the campaign begins?
- What are they afraid of that they have never told anyone?
- What do they believe about death?

This page never appears in the game. It informs the texture of every line written for this character during production. Players will feel its

weight without knowing its content [2].

Step N4.9 — Hero's Journey Arc Shape (5 sentences per character)

For each major character, write one sentence per stage [2]:

1. **Ordinary World:** Who are they before the war demands something of them?
2. **Call and Refusal:** What does the war ask of them that conflicts with who they are?
3. **Road of Trials:** What does each major battle cost them — tactically and morally?
4. **Innermost Cave / Dharmic Crisis:** The moment where their central fear has no clean answer.
5. **Return:** Do they return transformed, broken, or constant — and why is that the honest answer for this character?

Pass condition:

For every major character, you can explain their arc shape, what they want vs. need, their role on the battlefield, and why a player who loses them would feel something specific — without referencing any dialogue.

Phase N5 — The Named Civilian Thread

Time estimate: 1 session (2–3 hours)
Output: 1 structured entry per civilian, appended to Cast Design Sheet

Named civilians (3–4 total) are the human face of the war's cost. They are not playable, but their presence and potential death is one of the primary emotional mechanisms in the game [2]. Harrison Pink's framework from GDC 2017 is the operational principle here: the player must be given a reason to care about a civilian *before* that civilian is ever at risk [2].

For each named civilian, define:

- **Introduction moment:** A 2–3 line scripted encounter (not a full scene) where the civilian does something specific that the player will remember. It must happen before any threat to them appears [2].
- **Campaign thread:** In which chapters do they appear? What is their trajectory?
- **Risk scenarios:** In what situations can they be lost, and what specific player decision leads to that outcome? Trace the decision tree backward. If no player decision caused it, redesign the scenario — that is condemnation, not guilt [2].
- **Permanent consequence:** What changes in the game world or in other characters' dialogue if they are lost?

Phase N6 — The Narrative Flowchart

Time estimate: 2–3 sessions (4–6 hours)
Output: A visual map + chapter list, appended to Narrative Spine

This is the production document — the one used to estimate writing workload and brief a writer, narrative director, or co-developer [2]. It converts the Story Treatment into a chapter-by-chapter spine.

What the Flowchart Contains:

- **Chapter list** with act boundaries marked (chapters 1–N, with Act 1/2/3 transitions labelled)
- **Major decision points** — every Consequential Fork location, what the choice is, and what each path acknowledges
- **Branch acknowledgments** — where the unchosen path returns as a "scar" in Act 3 [2] (per the shallow-fork / deep-consequence model)
- **Character introduction and exit points** — when each named character enters the story, when they may exit permanently (death or departure), and which of those exits is player-determined vs. scripted
- **Civilian thread appearance points** — every chapter where a named civilian appears, and every chapter where their safety is at risk
- **Support/relationship milestones** — which chapters trigger key relationship developments (not content, just placement)

- **Dharmic dilemma windows** — which chapters contain the major recruit-choice dilemmas (the Dharmic Dilemma Recruits system from Cluster E [1])

The Shallow Fork Rule:

The guide is explicit: "A shallow fork with deep consequences is more powerful than a deep fork with shallow consequences. You do not need two full parallel campaigns." [2] The Consequential Fork in the flowchart should show: the moment of choice, the player's explicit declaration of what they are giving up, and one major Act 3 callback that acknowledges the unchosen path. That is the full investment required to create the feeling of a branching narrative [2].

Pass condition:

A producer can read the flowchart and calculate: number of scripted scenes, number of branching choice moments, number of character introductions and exits, and approximate number of support conversations required. This is the number that feeds workload estimation.

Phase N7 — The Moral Architecture Audit

Time estimate: 1 session (2–3 hours)
Output: An audit table, appended to Narrative Spine

Before the Narrative Spine is declared complete, every major moral choice in the game must be audited against two frameworks [2]. This audit prevents the most common failure mode in morally-weighted games: accidentally converting ethical choices into optimisation decisions.

Audit 1 — Worch's Four Criteria

For every major choice (Consequential Forks, Dharmic Dilemma Recruits, Named Civilian scenarios), verify [2]:

Criterion	Test
Legible stakes	Does the player understand what they might gain AND lose before choosing?
Genuine trade-off	Is it "choose between two things you value" rather than "good vs. bad"?
Proportionate consequence	Can the player see what their choice caused, even if not immediately?
Irreversibility	Is this choice explicitly and permanently unchosen?

Any choice failing more than one criterion must be redesigned before the document is locked [2].

Audit 2 — Guilt vs. Condemnation Check

For every scenario where a named civilian or character can be lost, ask [2]:

- Is the loss traceable to a specific decision the player made — even if they didn't know they were making it?
- Was that decision available to the player (i.e., they had genuine agency)?
- If the answer to either question is "no" — the scenario is condemnation, not guilt, and must be redesigned.

Audit 3 — The Morality Meter Check

For every moral choice in the game, ask: does this choice connect to any mechanical benefit or numerical penalty? If yes, remove the mechanical connection [2]. The War's Ledger shows cost, not score. The correct validation: if a player asks "what's the optimal choice for my karma stat," the design has failed. If a player asks "what's the right thing to do here?" — even rhetorically — the design has succeeded [2].

The Complete Deliverable: The Narrative Spine Document

When all six phases are complete, the Narrative Spine document contains:

Section	Content	Purpose
Story Seed	1 sentence	Conceptual anchor; scope filter
World Spine	2 pages	Conflict architecture; faction design
Three-Act Treatment	2–3 pages	Campaign shape; scope lock
Cast Design Sheet	1 page × N characters	Character arcs; production scope
Named Civilian Thread	Short entries × 3–4 civilians	Emotional thread design
Narrative Flowchart	Visual map + chapter list	Production planning; workload calculation
Moral Architecture Audit	Audit table	Quality gate; redesign trigger

This document does not contain a single line of dialogue, a single scene description, or a single piece of lore. It contains everything needed to estimate how much writing the game requires, how many writers would be needed and for how long, and what type of narrative expertise is needed (branching dialogue, linear campaign writing, worldbuilding, etc.) [1].

How This Feeds Workforce and Budget Decisions

Once the Narrative Flowchart exists, the following numbers become calculable — all of which are inputs to the Phase 4 workforce estimation already in your existing TODO list [1]:

- **Total scripted scenes:** Count from flowchart (pre-battle + post-battle + camp + key narrative moments)
- **Total branching moments:** Count Consequential Forks × acknowledgment callbacks
- **Total support conversation slots:** Number of A/B/C rank conversations × character count
- **Total character introduction moments:** Named civilians + recruits + commanders
- **Dialogue word count estimate:** Industry baseline for tactical RPGs is ~150–300 words per scripted scene. Multiply by scene count for range.
- **Writing time estimate:** An experienced solo writer can produce 1,000–2,000 polished game-dialogue words per day. Divide word count by that figure for person-days.
- **Localisation scope:** If the above produces a number too large for one developer to write and localise, that is the trigger for hiring a narrative writer or narrative director.

Total Time Estimate for the Full Plan

Phase	Estimated Time
N1 — Story Seed	2–3 hours
N2 — World Spine	4–6 hours
N3 — Story Treatment	8–12 hours
N4 — Cast Design Sheet	6–10 hours
N5 — Named Civilian Thread	2–3 hours
N6 — Narrative Flowchart	4–6 hours
N7 — Moral Architecture Audit	2–3 hours
Total	**~28–43 hours**

Across focused half-day sessions of 3–4 hours, this is approximately **8–12 working days** of narrative design work before a single word of the game is written. That is a very small investment relative to the production scope it unlocks.

What This Plan Does NOT Include (By Design)

The following are explicitly out of scope for the Narrative Spine document and belong to production, not pre-production [2]:

- Individual scene walkthroughs (Step 4 in the guide's five-step process)
- Dialogue writing (Step 5 — last, always last)
- Exact chapter map objectives or level layouts
- Lore documents, codex entries, or in-world texts
- Support conversation content (the specific words of A/B/C rank supports)

The moment you find yourself writing any of the above during this plan, stop. You have crossed from narrative design into production writing. Finish the plan first [2].

References

1. next-steps-todo.md - # Game Development — Sequenced TODO List

From Design Analysis → Scope-Locked GDD → Grey-Box Prot…

2. Narrative-Design-Guide.pdf - Compiled from GDC Talks, Industry Expert Interviews, and Essential Compiled from GDC Talks, Industry...
3. 2-Page-Game-Description.pdf - Genre:
   Tactical RPG

Verbs:
Plan – choose battles, select army, manage supplies, decide routes....